Navigation Company is a venture in an altogether new direction'![45] Prescient though this remark is, he could have had little premonition of its vicissitudes in its short life.

Bankers

SSNCo had initially banked with the National Bank of India. Flooded with questions about why a Swadeshi company should choose a European firm VOC responded that it was only an initial decision made for convenience and promised not to deposit another paisa in a non-Indian bank. Further, he clarified that all funds were now parked with Haji Fakir Muhammed Sait whose worth ran into many lakhs of rupees. Funds collected since 1 November, he said, were deposited with firms such as the V.E.N.K.R.MA., A.L.A.R., A.R.A.R.S.—all Nattukottai Chettiar bankers based in Tuticorin. With the grace of the almighty and Mother India, he said, no harm would come to the company's funds. He also used this opportunity to take a pot-shot at some unnamed rich men who had planned to exploit the company—these men remained unnamed; they were possibly some Tuticorin bankers who were not committed to the Swadeshi cause but nursed mercenary interests. If only Indians had invested in Indian firms, VOC added, disasters such as the collapse of the Arbuthnot and Company and the run-on Binnys could have been avoided. Perhaps this was a reference to the four proposed directors who dropped out at the time of registration. In the end, he said, all was for the good, and once again reassured the public that the rise of India and the East was inevitable.[46]

In this regard, VOC also had to contend with criticism about the locus of Indian banks with which the company would transact business. If the company restricted itself to Madras banks, as some insisted, it would reflect badly on the trust in Bombay and Calcutta institutions. Writing—appropriately from Bombay—he asked: if one discriminated between one's own presidency and other presidencies, how could Indians ever forge unity and advance into nationhood?[47]